Interview Questions – Part B: Open-Ended Qualitative Questions (50 minutes)

Now, I would like to ask some questions to understand your experiences with buying and preparing food and using food assistance programs (such as SNAP or food stamps, food pantries, and school lunch programs) and how refugee organizations have helped you with food.

Questions on food and nutrition insecurity experiences and using food programs (40 minutes)

1. Tell me about your experience in buying and preparing food for your household in the U.S.

   During this times that we are in, I told you how food has gotten expensive, but we try our best. The way we used to buy back then and now it's different, but we try our best.

   Follow up: Where do you get groceries?

   Costco, and Walmart

   Follow up: Do you have cooking appliances, and do you know how to use it?

   Yes, and we know how to use them

   Follow up: Do you get enough food?

   When I get paid, I do groceries and the money gets finished, and I don't save anything

2. Review answers in the Food Insecurity sections and ask the following questions if they have experienced food insecurity in the last 12 months; if not, go to question #3:
   a. You indicated that you often/sometimes had problems with food in the last 12 months, can you tell me more about that?

      There's sometimes when you face challenges of sickness and then you have to pay medical bills in addition to buying food. For example, I had challenges of sickness, and now I have to pay a lot of medical bills, which makes it hard to get enough money for groceries.

      Follow up: Did you apply for assistance like food stamp?

      Yes, we tried to apply for it but they said that we make enough money.

   b. Can you explain what you did to find help with food and if that worked?

      We tried to apply for food stamp, but they told us that we make enough money. But whenever food becomes less, we usually go to church to get free food.

   c. Can you explain how your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> helped you with food?

      CCS helped us a lot, because when we reached here, I did not get a job right away and they helped us pay for rent and other things.

i. What has been most useful to you among things that your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> do?

They gave us food stamp and Medicaid.

Follow up: Did CCS help show you where to get groceries?

CCS gave us volunteers and they are the ones that helped us a lot. They took us to stores and showed us how to do groceries.

ii. Is there anything that you wish you had learned or could learn from caseworkers of <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> to help you with food?

d. Can you tell me when food became a problem?

Food became a problem during these times when food has gotten very expensive. Before this, food was not a big problem.

e. Review answers in the Utilization section and ask the following questions if they have used SNAP/WIC/NSLP/Food Pantries/Other programs in the last 12 months; if not go to #f below:

i. You indicated that you have used NSLP program, can you tell me how you heard about this program and how you applied for it?

We knew about the program before. Because we reached here, all of my kids had free lunch. CCS told us about the program.

ii. Can you explain your experience with using this program?

Sometimes, a child comes home from school when he is very hungry and finds food at home. But this does not happen a lot.

f. Review answers in the Utilization section and ask the following questions if they have NOT used SNAP/WIC/NSLP/Food Pantries/Other programs in the last 12 months:

i. You indicated that you often/sometimes had problems with food in the last 12 months. Can you tell me why you have not used food assistance programs during these times?

We applied for food stamp, but they told us that we make enough money.

ii. Can you explain your experiences with applying for food programs since you graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

Refugee center is the one that helps us. Because when you graduate from CCS and are no longer with DWS, refugee center has people designated to help you.

Follow up: How did you know about the Refugee Center program?

Refugee center has people who are African, and they help you when you need help. Because even to find the job that I have now, refugee center is the one that helped me to find it.

3. Tell me about your experience in finding and buying foods from your culture.

a. How important eating foods from your culture is to you?

We buy dry fish and vegetables from Africa. We like food from Africa a lot because it's food that does not have a lot of fats.

b. Where do you get your vegetables and cultural foods from?
We get them from the African stores.
c. How does/did <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> help you with finding foods from your culture?
    i. What did they do that was the most helpful and why?
    What helped us a lot is, they used to show us vegetables to cook.
d. Do you use Farmers Market to buy foods from your culture?
Yes. There are people that farm some fresh food. So, when it's in season, we buy the fresh food.
e. Have you used the Sunnyvale Farmers Market (4013 S 700 W)?
    i. if yes, how did you hear about it and what has been your experience with that?
    Yes, it's the one we get the vegetables from.
    My experience has been good because we get vegetables which are good. I learned about from friends who also have those gardens.

Suggestions for future strategies to improve food access (10 minutes)

1. What do you think keeps people from your community from using food assistance programs that are available to them?
What can hinder them is, if you don't have food stamp and food is expensive.
If you don't have a job, you can apply for food stamp.
Follow up: What do you think can hinder someone from using the assistance programs?
Sometimes you can be very sick, but usually you have someone to take care of you, and so that person can help you to look for assistance programs.
Follow up: What do you think prohibits people from using the assistance programs available to them.
Maybe if you don't have anyone to guide you, and you don't speak the language. But here, if you can't manage to take care of yourself, you usually have someone designated to help you. Like you can go to the agency that welcomed you here to help.
2. How do you think we can ensure that refugees can access food assistance programs when they need help with food?
Maybe, asking for us. Like the refugee center, if you don't have a way to ask for assistance, you can go to them, and they can help you.
3. What do you think <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> and other refugee organizations can do to ensure refugees have enough food?
Sometimes you have problems, like not working; CCS is the one supposed to help us, with assistance needed for us to survive
4. Do you want to share anything else regarding your experiences with food insecurity and using food assistance programs since you moved to the U.S. and since you graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?
When you have food stamp, it's good to take a good care of it and also look for a job to help yourself.

What I can add on; see like now, I got surgery and they have been sending me so much bills. My husband also recently got surgery. Before, when you have like that bill, they used to help us and pay for the bill. But now, there's no one to help you. You are on your own.

Follow up: Did the bill not have contacts for the assistance program?

They have the numbers. I tried to call them, and they were asking me for many things including my husband's income information yet he is not in a capable of paying the bill.

Follow up: Do you think the medical bills are the ones hindering you from having enough food?

Yes. Because they get money from my account. So, when I see that my account is empty after they have taken their money, if I had plans to go and buy some food, I can't go to buy them.